

From Oral Tradition to Digital Future: Documenting the History and Current Vitality of the Mising Language through Community Initiatives

A COMMUNITY-BASED RESEARCH PAPER

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MISING LANGUAGE	TANI LANGUAGES	ENDANGERED LANGUAGES	NLP
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ABSTRACT

The Mising language, a member of the Tani branch of the Sino-Tibetan family spoken primarily in the Brahmaputra Valley of Assam, India, faces mounting pressures from linguistic assimilation, urbanisation, and intergenerational transmission failure. Classified as endangered by UNESCO, Mising occupies a complex sociolinguistic position as the language of Assam's second-largest tribal community, yet remains significantly under-resourced in digital and computational spaces. In this paper, I present a synthesis of insights drawn from the 1st Mising Literary Conclave organised by the Takam Mising Porin Kébang (TMPK) Gauhati City Committee on 8 November 2025 at Krishnakanta Handique State Open University, Guwahati — a landmark community gathering of linguists, scholars, students, and cultural advocates. Drawing on the proceedings, expert talks, and a paper I co-presented on behalf of the Assam Down Town University Mising Students' Union (ADTU MSU) on the language's origin and evolution, I examine the historical trajectory of Mising, its current endangerment status, and pathways toward revitalisation. I argue that grassroots community mobilisation, when coupled with emerging AI and NLP technologies — particularly large language models (LLMs), automatic speech recognition, and digital archiving platforms — offers a viable and inclusive model for language preservation in Northeast India's multilingual landscape.

Keywords: Mising language, Tani languages, endangered languages, language documentation, NLP, Northeast India, LLMs, digital preservation

1. INTRODUCTION

Languages are not merely vehicles of communication; they are archives of accumulated human knowledge, cosmology, ecological understanding, and cultural identity. When a language falls silent, an irreplaceable epistemological universe is lost. Across the globe, roughly 40% of the estimated 7,000 living languages are at risk of disappearing within the next century (UNESCO, 2003), and the languages of Northeast India — one of the world's most linguistically diverse regions — are disproportionately represented among those at greatest risk.

I write this paper as a member of the Mising community and a BCA student at Assam Down Town University, Guwahati. My community speaks Mising (also rendered as Mishing or Miri in older colonial-era literature), a Tani language of the Sino-Tibetan family spoken by over half a million people primarily across the districts of Dhemaji, Lakhimpur, Majuli, Dibrugarh, Sivasagar, and Jorhat. Despite a sizeable speaker population, Mising has been classified as endangered — a status that reflects not raw numbers but the fragility of intergenerational transmission, limited institutional support, and near-absence in digital spaces.

This paper situates itself at the intersection of community-led language revitalisation and emerging computational tools. My primary source of insight is the 1st Mising Literary Conclave, held on 8 November 2025 in Guwahati — the most significant gathering of Mising linguistic scholars and community advocates in recent memory. I attended as a representative of the ADTU Mising Students' Union (ADTU MSU) and co-presented a paper on the origin and evolution of the Mising language.

The paper proceeds as follows: Section 2 traces the historical journey of the Mising language from oral tradition to early documentation. Section 3 analyses its current sociolinguistic challenges. Section 4 reports on the Literary Conclave as a case study in community mobilisation. Section 5 examines the potential of AI and NLP tools for Mising's digital future. Section 6 offers conclusions and actionable recommendations.

"Languages do not die because of enemies — they die because of indifference. Revival must begin in everyday domestic, campus, and digital spaces."

— Srishti Rani Taid, Award-Winning Young Poet & Author, Assam · 1st Mising Literary Conclave, 2025

2. HISTORICAL JOURNEY OF THE MISING LANGUAGE

2.1 Origins and Migration

The Mising people are believed to have originated in the high-altitude regions of Tibet, migrating southward through the hills of present-day Arunachal Pradesh before gradually descending into the Brahmaputra plains of Assam — a settlement process estimated to have occurred between the 13th and 15th centuries CE (Cotton University Mising Students' Circle, 2025; Arya Vidyapeeth College Students, 2025). This migration narrative is embedded in oral tradition, ritual song, and the very phonological character of the language,

which retains structural features shared with its highland Tani cognates — Adi, Galo, Nishi, and others spoken across Arunachal Pradesh.

Linguistically, Mising belongs to the Tani sub-group of the Tibeto-Burman language family. Its closest cognate varieties include the Padam, Pasi, Pagro, Pangi, Milang, and Minyong languages of Arunachal Pradesh (Gauhati Commerce College Students' Union, 2025). The language exists as a dialect continuum, and scholars have identified six principal dialects: Pagro, Delu, Mo:ying, Dambug, Sa:yang, and Oyan, distributed across different geographic zones of the Brahmaputra Valley (Vissar, 2025). While broadly mutually intelligible, these dialects exhibit significant phonological, morpho-phonological, and morpho-syntactic divergences that complicate standardisation efforts.

2.2 From Oral Tradition to Early Documentation

Historically, Mising was an exclusively oral language. Rich traditions of sung narratives, ritual speech, myth-telling, and daily discourse formed the backbone of cultural transmission across generations. The Dobur Uie (festival of rice beer), the Po:Reng harvest dance, and the oral epics associated with the supreme deity Donyi-Polo exemplify a vibrant tradition that relied entirely on memory and performance rather than inscription.

The earliest external documentation of the Mising language came through colonial administration. J. Herbert Lorrain's *A Dictionary of the Abor-Miri Language* (1901) and George Grierson's monumental *Linguistic Survey of India* (1909) offered the first systematic records, albeit through the distorting lens of colonial linguistic categories (ADTU MSU, 2025). These early works, while imperfect, remain valuable primary records of the language's earlier phonological and lexical states.

2.3 Modern Standardisation Efforts

Indigenous-led documentation began in earnest in the latter half of the 20th century. A landmark event was the establishment of the Mising Agom Kébang (MAK — Mising Language Organization) in 1972, which undertook the standardisation of the language and advocated for its official recognition (TMPK Handique College Unit, 2025; Pegu, 2025). MAK adopted a modified Roman script for Mising — a pragmatic and politically significant choice that distinguished the language from the dominant Assamese script, asserting a distinct cultural identity. This script remains in active use today.

Pioneering scholars such as Prof. Taburam Taid and Nahendra Padun anchored the academic phase of Mising language development. Notable publications include Padun's *Mising Bhasar Lipi: Ek Porikhyamulok Aasoni* (1969), the collaborative *Mising Agom Ayyir* by Taid and Padun (1971), Taid's *Mising Gomlam Potin* (2010), and *A Dictionary of the Mising Language* (1995). These texts established the orthographic and grammatical foundations upon which contemporary educational and cultural materials are being built.

Doctoral research has further deepened the academic record. Key theses include Basanta Kumar Doley's *A Morphological Study of the Mising Language* (1996), Jugendra Pegu's *Dialectal Variations in Mising and the Interference of Dominant Languages* (2010), and Dipak Kumar Doley's doctoral study of Padam-Pagro dialectal variation (2017). These works collectively constitute a growing but still incomplete body of scientific knowledge about Mising's structure and sociolinguistic situation.

3. CURRENT STATUS AND CHALLENGES

3.1 *Endangered Status and Vitality Indicators*

Mising's designation as an endangered language by UNESCO reflects a constellation of sociolinguistic pressures rather than any numerical decline in speaker population. As observed during the Literary Conclave, the critical factors are the weakening of intergenerational transmission, reduced domains of use, and declining prestige among younger speakers (ADTU MSU, 2025; Doley, JNU, 2025). Many Mising children now grow up using Mising in domestic settings but shift decisively to Assamese or English in educational, social, and digital environments.

3.2 *Orthographic and Standardisation Challenges*

One of the most structurally significant obstacles facing Mising today is the absence of a universally accepted writing standard. Despite MAK's adoption of the Roman script, multiple competing orthographic conventions exist, leading to inconsistent spelling across textbooks, literary publications, and digital content (Doley, S.K., 2025; Pegu, J., 2025). This multiplicity creates practical barriers to producing cohesive teaching materials, discourages digital content creators uncertain of correct forms, and impedes the development of computational linguistic resources such as corpora and spell-checkers.

3.3 *Bilingualism, Language Shift, and Urbanisation*

The Mising community is highly bilingual, with most speakers commanding Assamese, and a substantial proportion also proficient in Hindi and English. While multilingualism carries intrinsic value, Doley (2025) notes that in the Mising context it has historically accelerated language shift rather than fostered stable multilingualism. Urban migration for education and employment disrupts community language networks that sustained regular Mising use, and the perceived economic and social utility of dominant languages exerts powerful pressure on language choices. Pegu (2025) describes a pattern of code-mixing and code-switching that, while creatively adaptive, signals a gradual retreat of Mising from formal and semi-formal domains.

3.4 *Educational Gaps*

The implementation of Mising-medium education remains partial and uneven. Under the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020's three-language formula, Assam has introduced Mising as a subject in approximately 200 lower primary schools across districts where Misings constitute a majority population (ADTU MSU, 2025; B. Borooh College Students, 2025). However, the pipeline of trained Mising language teachers is insufficient, pedagogical materials are inadequate, and the language remains largely absent from higher levels of formal education.

3.5 *Digital Marginalisation*

Perhaps the most consequential challenge in the contemporary moment — and one felt acutely as a computer science student — is Mising's near-total absence from digital infrastructure. There is no widely used Unicode-compatible Mising font, no official keyboard layout, no significant corpus of digitised text, and minimal representation in social media, online news, or streaming content (ADTU MSU, 2025). Without digital presence, a language becomes invisible to younger generations who inhabit primarily digital

communicative environments, and it remains inaccessible to the computational tools — language models, speech recognisers, machine translation systems — that increasingly mediate access to information and public services.

3.6 The Somua Mising: A Case of Identity Dissolution

A particularly urgent sub-case highlighted at the Literary Conclave concerns the Somua Mising (also Somua Miri) communities of East Siang and Lohit districts in Arunachal Pradesh. These communities, geographically separated from the main Assamese Mising population, have undergone extensive assimilation with Adi and Galo communities, adopting their surnames and cultural practices, and are losing their distinct linguistic identity at an accelerating pace (Pegu, J., 2025). Their situation illustrates how geographic isolation and absence of institutional support can produce irreversible language loss even within a community that nominally shares the same language.

4. THE FIRST MISING LITERARY CONCLAVE: A COMMUNITY EFFORT

4.1 Background and Significance

The 1st Mising Literary Conclave, organised by the Takam Mising Porin Kébang (TMPK) Gauhati City Committee and held on 8 November 2025 at Krishnakanta Handique State Open University, Guwahati, represented a watershed moment in the organised effort to document, analyse, and revitalise the Mising language. Bringing together linguists, university researchers, educators, students, poets, and community leaders under one roof, the Conclave created an unprecedented space for cross-institutional dialogue on Mising's linguistic future.

The event was chaired and shaped by Dr. Jugendra Pegu, Assistant Professor of English at Jonai Girls' College, Assam. Invited resource persons included Dr. Eline Vissar (Uppsala University, Sweden), Dr. Sarat K. Doley (Tezpur University), Dr. Krishna Boro (Gauhati University), Aleendra Brahma (CIIL, Mysuru), and prominent multilingual writer and youth advocate Srishti Rani Taid.

4.2 Key Academic Contributions

Dr. Eline Visser Uppsala University, Sweden <i>"Evolution, Problems, and Youth's Role in Shaping the Future of Tibeto-Burman Languages" — framed documentation as a multipurpose enduring record; introduced LLMs for Mising.</i>	Dr. Sarat K. Doley Associate Professor of English, Tezpur University <i>"Various Problems in Tani Languages" — rigorous sociolinguistic diagnosis of structural threats to the Tani language family.</i>
Dr. Jugendra Pegu Asst. Professor of English, Jonai Girls' College, Assam <i>"Contemporary Issues of the Mising Language: Challenges and Solutions" — dialectology, codification, and teacher training.</i>	Dr. Krishna Boro Dept. of Linguistics, Gauhati University <i>"Evolution and Origin of the Mising Language" — community-driven documentation approaches and archiving platforms.</i>

Srishti Rani Taid

Award-Winning Young Poet & Author, Assam

*Youth Speaker — the moral duty of Mising youth; language revival as an everyday ethical choice.***Aleendra Brahma**

CIIL Mysuru, Dept. of Higher Education, Govt. of India

"Youth's Role in Shaping the Future of the Mising Language and the Technology-Driven Way Forward"

4.3 Student Paper Presentations and ADTU MSU Contribution

A distinguishing feature of the Conclave was the active participation of student groups from multiple Guwahati institutions, including B. Borooah College, Handique College, Kamashree Hiteswar Saikia College, Gauhati Commerce College, Cotton University, Arya Vidyapeeth College, and Assam Down Town University. This multi-institutional student engagement signalled a growing recognition within academic youth culture that language preservation is not only a scholarly but also a civic responsibility.

As a representative of the Assam Down Town University Mising Students' Union (ADTU MSU), I co-presented a paper titled *"Origin and Evolution of the Mising Language."* In that paper, my team and I traced the Tibeto-Burman lineage of Mising, the community's settlement history in the Eastern Brahmaputra Valley, and the trajectory of documentation from early colonial records through the contributions of MAK and pioneering scholars Taburam Taid and Nahendra Padun.

A central concern of our ADTU MSU presentation was the challenge of digital exclusion: the absence of Unicode-compatible fonts, official keyboard layouts, and online content in Mising. We called for a structured digital preservation initiative encompassing audio-visual archiving, e-book conversion of existing texts, and the development of AI and NLP tools specifically engineered for Mising.

4.4 Conclave Outcomes and Forward Momentum

The Conclave concluded with closing addresses by Tilak Doley, President of TMPK, and Cedric Lagachu, President of the TMPK Guwahati City Committee, both of whom emphasised the existential stakes of language loss and committed to expanding the frequency and reach of such community gatherings. The consensus across presentations converged on several actionable priorities: codifying dialectal variation into a workable standard, scaling teacher training, expanding Mising's presence in print and digital media, and building computational resources for the language.

5. TOWARDS DIGITALISATION: AI & TECHNOLOGY OPPORTUNITIES FOR MISING

5.1 The Computational Resource Gap

The development of NLP tools for low-resource languages like Mising requires three foundational elements: a substantial digitised text corpus, high-quality labelled audio data, and a standardised Unicode-compatible writing system. For Mising, all three remain nascent or absent. However, recent advances in transfer learning, multilingual models, and zero-shot/few-shot learning have significantly lowered the data requirements for building functional NLP tools, making the ambition of Mising language technology more achievable than it was even a decade ago (Vissar, 2025; Doley, JNU, 2025).

5.2 Large Language Models and Mising

LLMs pre-trained on massively multilingual corpora — including models in the Llama, Gemma, and multilingual BERT families — can serve as effective base architectures for low-resource language adaptation when fine-tuned on even modest amounts of Mising data. The Conclave's discussions, particularly Dr. Vissar's keynote, identified several priority applications:

- **Speech Recognition & Voice Interfaces**
ASR systems trained on collected Mising audio could enable voice-based access to digital services, particularly for elders with lower literacy.
- **Speech-to-Text & Machine Translation**
Systems capable of transcribing and translating Mising speech would dramatically lower the barrier to documentation by community volunteers without specialised linguistic training.
- **Text Generation & Document Production**
LLMs adapted for Mising could assist in generating educational materials, official correspondence, and literary content.
- **Spell-Checking & Grammar Assistance**
Basic NLP tools could support Mising writers and students, particularly given existing orthographic inconsistencies.

5.3 Digital Archiving and Corpus Building

A pre-condition for all downstream NLP development is the systematic digitisation of existing Mising materials. Dr. Krishna Boro's emphasis on community-sourced documentation aligns with contemporary best practices in endangered language technology, where platforms such as Aikuma (a mobile-based recording app) and the SIL FieldWorks Language Explorer have demonstrated that non-specialist community members can meaningfully contribute to corpus building (Boro, 2025). Repositories such as PARADISEC and Zenodo, highlighted by Dr. Vissar, provide the archival infrastructure for permanent, globally accessible storage.

In the ADTU MSU paper at the Conclave, my team proposed a phased digital preservation roadmap: (1) Unicode font and keyboard development; (2) audio-visual documentation of oral traditions from community elders; (3) digitisation and e-book conversion of existing printed grammars, dictionaries, and literary works; (4) a centralised web-accessible repository for Mising texts and recordings; and (5) training workshops to enable youth to contribute to these archives using smartphones and open-source tools.

5.4 NLP Research Directions

For the AI research community working on Northeast Indian languages, Mising presents a compelling and largely unexplored case study. Based on participation in the Conclave and a background in computer science, I identify the following research priorities:

Dialectal Variation Modelling	Given the six recognised dialects, computational approaches to dialect identification, normalisation, and cross-dialect intelligibility could serve both linguistic research and practical applications such as multi-dialectal spell-checking.
Morphological Analysis	Mising is a morphologically complex language with agglutinative features. A robust morphological analyser is a foundational NLP component for further downstream tasks.

Code-Switching Detection & Analysis	The prevalent Mising-Assamese code-switching in everyday speech represents both a sociolinguistic phenomenon of intrinsic interest and a practical challenge for ASR and NLP systems that must handle mixed-language input.
Educational Technology	AI-powered Mising language learning applications — vocabulary trainers, pronunciation guides, interactive reading platforms — could significantly support mother-tongue literacy development in contexts where trained teachers are scarce.

5.5 Youth as Digital Agents

A recurring theme across the Conclave was the centrality of youth not merely as recipients of revitalisation efforts but as active agents of digital documentation and content creation. Social media platforms — YouTube, Instagram, Facebook, and TikTok — were repeatedly cited as accessible arenas for Mising content production. Srishti Rani Taid's call for youth to write, speak, and create in Mising even imperfectly — to prioritise practice over fluency — maps directly onto the logic of community-generated training data for NLP systems.

"Every Mising-language post, podcast episode, or video contributes to the digital corpus from which future language models can learn. Cultural practice and computational resource generation are the same act."

— Mahatma Doley, ADTU MSU, based on Conclave discussions, 2025

6. CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

The Mising language stands at a critical juncture. Its rich oral traditions, the dedicated scholarship of its linguists, the energy of its student communities, and the mobilising capacity of organisations like TMPK and MAK constitute genuine assets. Yet the structural pressures of linguistic assimilation, educational marginalisation, and digital invisibility are severe, and the window for effective intervention is finite.

Attending the 1st Mising Literary Conclave and presenting on behalf of the ADTU Mising Students' Union was a formative experience — one that deepened my understanding of my community's linguistic heritage and sharpened my sense of responsibility as someone positioned at the intersection of technology and culture. In this paper, I have attempted to translate the insights of that gathering into a coherent scholarly contribution. I close with the following recommendations:

1	Standardisation	Convene a representative dialectological committee to develop a consensus orthographic standard, accompanied by style guides, Unicode font sets, and keyboard layouts, disseminated through schools, MAK, and digital channels.
2	Teacher Training	Establish a dedicated Mising language teacher training programme, potentially in partnership with Tezpur University, Gauhati University, or IIT Guwahati, and expand NEP 2020's mother-tongue instruction provisions.

3	Digital Corpus Building	Launch a community-led audio-visual documentation drive, training youth volunteers to record oral traditions from elders using smartphones, and depositing materials in PARADISEC or a dedicated Mising language digital repository.
4	AI & NLP Development	Establish an interdisciplinary research initiative — connecting linguists, computer scientists, and community members — to develop foundational NLP resources: a labelled text corpus, a morphological analyser, and an ASR prototype leveraging multilingual LLM fine-tuning.
5	Annual Literary Conclave	Institutionalise the Mising Literary Conclave as an annual event, rotating between Guwahati, Dhemaji, and Majuli, to sustain scholarly momentum and broaden community engagement.
6	Digital Content Campaigns	Partner with youth organisations and social media influencers to run structured campaigns producing Mising-language content on YouTube, Instagram, and podcasting platforms, expanding the language's digital footprint while simultaneously building training data for future NLP systems.

The case of Mising is, in many ways, representative of dozens of Northeast Indian languages navigating the same pressures. The intersection of community mobilisation and computational technology offers a novel and promising model for language revitalisation — one in which the tools of the digital age are placed, democratically and urgently, in the hands of the communities that need them most.

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